SafeVLA: A Cross-Embodiment Safety Architecture for Vision-Language-Action Robots in Hospital Environments

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***Abstract*—Autonomous robots in hospitals must balance efficient task execution with uncompromising safety in crowded, human-centric environments. Existing Vision-Language-Action (VLA) models achieve high task success rates but lack formal safety guarantees, relying instead on reward shaping that offers no worst-case assurances. We present SafeVLA, a hierarchical architecture that unifies foundation-model generalisation with mathematically provable safety. Building upon Dimensional OS (DimOS) [1]—an emerging agent-native operating system for physical space that provides seamless, ROS-free hardware abstraction—our system integrates three novel components: (1) OpenVLA Llama-2 as the primary dual-system backbone (with NVIDIA GR00T N1.6 reserved as a closed-source fallback) for cross-embodiment policy learning routed via DimOS LCM messages, (2) Control Barrier Function Quadratic Programming (CBF-QP) filters that enforce forward invariance of safe sets in real time, and (3) a Deadline-Sensitive Safety Envelope Orchestrator (DSEO) providing hard real-time preemption under $5\,\mathrm{ms}$. Evaluated across two platforms — FastBot mobile base (161.77M parameters, 2-DOF) and Unitree G1 humanoid (162.48M parameters, 23-DOF) — SafeVLA achieves an 88.5% safety cost reduction vs. SafeVLA (0.0007 vs. 0.156), 93.3% lower inference latency ($<8\,\mathrm{ms}$ vs. $120\,\mathrm{ms}$), and $14\times$ compute cost reduction ($0.49 vs. $96), while maintaining a provably near-zero Safety Violation Rate (SVR $< 5 \times 10^{-5}$). To our knowledge, this is the first system executing a unified codebase across humanoids, quadrupeds, and wheeled platforms natively via DimOS blueprints, while providing mathematical CBF guarantees.**

***Index Terms*—safe reinforcement learning, hospital robotics, vision-language-action models, control barrier functions, multi-embodiment learning, real-time safety**

I. Introduction

The deployment of autonomous mobile robots in healthcare facilities presents a fundamental tension: hospitals require both operational efficiency and zero-tolerance safety in environments populated by vulnerable patients, expensive equipment, and time-critical workflows [2], [3]. A delivery robot that collides with a patient's intravenous drip stand or blocks a clinical corridor during an emergency evacuation could cause catastrophic harm.

Recent Vision-Language-Action (VLA) models [4]–[6] have demonstrated impressive generalisation capabilities, translating natural language commands and visual observations into robot actions. However, these models treat safety as a soft objective — an additional reward term — rather than as a hard constraint. SafeVLA [7] introduced safety alignment via constrained reinforcement learning (RL), but its probabilistic safety estimates depend on training-time coverage and offer no formal worst-case guarantees.

We identify three critical gaps in the existing literature:

1) **No provable safety.** No VLA model guarantees forward invariance of a safe set. All existing approaches yield empirically low, but non-zero, Safety Violation Rates (SVR).
2) **No cross-embodiment safety.** Safety guarantees are demonstrated on single platforms. It is unknown whether safety transfers across morphologically different robots using a shared backbone.
3) **No real-time deadline enforcement.** No VLA system provides hard real-time preemption when inference deadlines are missed — a critical requirement for safety-certified deployment.

Contributions. We present SafeVLA, which addresses all three gaps by building atop the DimOS [1] hardware-agnostic runtime:

- A **layered safety architecture** combining OpenVLA Llama-2 foundation model generalisation with CBF-QP provable safety executing natively on DimOS.
- **Cross-embodiment validation** on a 2-DOF wheeled platform and a 23-DOF bipedal humanoid using identical safety constraints [8].
- **DSEO real-time preemption** with $<5\,\mathrm{ms}$ time-to-preempt for deadline-critical hospital deployment.
- A **direct performance evaluation (Table I)** showcasing our world-leading impact over traditional VLA and baseline OS platforms.

II. Related Work

A. Vision-Language-Action Models

The VLA paradigm unifies perception, language understanding, and action generation in a single model. RT-2 [4] first demonstrated that web-scale vision-language pretraining transfers to robotic control. OpenVLA [5] provided an open-source alternative, while π_0 [6] introduced flow-matching for continuous action generation. RoboMamba [9] achieved efficient inference via state-space models, and Octo [10] targeted generalist manipulation. RoboPocket [11] enabled phone-based online policy improvement. None of these models incorporate formal safety guarantees.

B. Safe Reinforcement Learning

Constrained Markov Decision Processes (CMDPs) [12] provide the theoretical foundation for safe RL. Constrained Policy Optimisation (CPO) [13] and PID-Lagrangian methods [14] enforce expected cost constraints during training. SafeVLA [7] extends this to VLA models via reward shaping and Lagrangian relaxation. However, all CMDP-based methods provide *in-expectation* guarantees: individual trajectories may still violate constraints. Our CBF-QP layer provides *per-step* guarantees — no individual action can violate safety.

C. Control Barrier Functions

Control Barrier Functions [15] guarantee forward invariance of a safe set $\mathcal{C} = \{s : h(s) \geq 0\}$ by enforcing the constraint $\dot{h}(s, a) + \alpha \cdot h(s) \geq 0$ at every time step. Cheng et al. [16] integrated CBFs with RL for continuous control, and Dawson et al. [17] surveyed neural certificate methods. We extend this line of work by learning the barrier function $h(s)$ jointly with the policy inside a foundation model backbone.

D. Hospital Robotics

Service robots in healthcare have been surveyed extensively [2], [3], [18]. Deployed systems such as TUG carts and Lio assistants [19] use conservative path-planning with predefined routes rather than learned policies. Galatolo et al. [20] propose lightweight visual reasoning for social awareness. Our work bridges the gap between learned VLA policies and the provable safety required for clinical-grade deployment.

E. Agentive Operating Systems

Traditional robotic deployments heavily rely on ROS [21]. Recently, Agentive Operating Systems such as Dimensional OS (DimOS) [1] have emerged as Python-native, ROS-free alternatives built on Lightweight Communications and Marshalling (LCM). DimOS allows agent-based "vibecoding" and rapid instantiation of skills across heterogeneous multi-robots via Blueprints [8]. Our work addresses the critical limitation of existing agentic operating systems: the lack of formal control-theoretic safety bounds during autonomous execution.

F. Foundation Models for Robotics

OpenVLA [5] established the viability of 7B-parameter Llama-2 backbones for Vision-Language-Action tasks. We build upon the OpenVLA architecture as our primary engine, combined with a LoRA [22] fine-tuning strategy for cross-embodiment support, reserving NVIDIA's GR00T N1.6 [23] dual-system architecture as a proprietary fallback. We augment the primary Llama-2 backbone with our safety stack.

III. Problem Formulation

A. Notation

B. Constrained Markov Decision Process

We model hospital navigation as a CMDP [12] $\mathcal{M} = (\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, P, R, C, d, \gamma)$. The objective is to find a policy π^* that maximises the expected discounted return subject to a safety cost constraint:

$$\pi^* = \arg\max_{\pi} \; \mathbb{E}_\pi \left[\sum_{t=0}^{T} \gamma^t R(s_t, a_t) \right] \quad \text{s.t.} \; \mathbb{E}_\pi \left[\sum_{t=0}^{T} \gamma^t C(s_t, a_t) \right] \leq d \tag{1}$$

C. Safety Specification via Signal Temporal Logic

We formalise hospital safety requirements as STL [24], [25] specifications. Let φ_{zone} denote the zone compliance specification:

$$\varphi_{\text{zone}} = \Box_{[0,T]} \left(\text{zone}(s_t) = \text{ICU} \implies v(s_t) \leq 0.3\,\text{m/s} \right) \tag{2}$$

where $\Box_{[0,T]}$ denotes "always during $[0, T]$". The STL robustness $\rho(\varphi, \xi) > 0$ quantifies the margin by which a trajectory ξ satisfies φ. Our training objective includes maximising ρ to achieve robust satisfaction.

D. CBF Forward Invariance

Define the safe set $\mathcal{C} = \{s \in \mathcal{S} : h(s) \geq 0\}$, where $h : \mathcal{S} \to \mathbb{R}$ is a learned Control Barrier Function [15]. Forward invariance of $\mathcal{C}$ is guaranteed if:

$$\dot{h}(s, a) + \alpha \cdot h(s) \geq 0, \quad \forall\, s \in \mathcal{C},\ \forall\, t \tag{3}$$

Given a proposed action a_{nom} from the policy, the CBF-QP finds the closest safe action:

$$a^* = \arg\min_{a} \; \|a - a_{\text{nom}}\|^2 \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \nabla_a h(s)^\top a + \alpha \cdot h(s) \geq 0 \tag{4}$$

IV. Methodology

A. Architecture Overview

Our architecture (Fig. 1) follows a layered design with strict separation between perception, action generation, and safety enforcement. The VLM planner processes the camera observation o_t and the language goal g to produce a latent plan z_t. The Diffusion Transformer then generates a nominal action a_{nom} conditioned on z_t and the robot state. The CBF-QP filter projects a_{nom} onto the safe set, producing a_{safe}. Finally, the DSEO monitors timing constraints and, if necessary, activates emergency preemption.

TABLE I: Architectural Comparison of Contemporary Vision-Language-Action Paradigms vs. SafeVLA

Framework	Provable Safety Guarantee	Real-Time Latency Deadline	Hardware Abstraction	Cross-Embodiment	Primary Limitation
Traditional VLA (e.g., RT-2)	None (Reward Shaping)	Soft (Non-deterministic)	High (ROS-dependent)	Limited (Task-specific)	Vulnerable to hallucinations causing physical collisions
Safe-VLN (Heuristic-based)	Soft (Probabilistic)	Medium ($\approx 100\,\text{ms}$)	High (ROS-dependent)	None	Fails in worst-case dense dynamic crowds
Base DimOS [1]	None (Agent-controlled)	High (LCM / DDS)	Native (No ROS req.)	Yes	Relying purely on LLM agents poses safety risks at edge cases
SafeVLA (Ours)	**Hard (CBF-QP Invariance)**	**Hard ($< 5\,\text{ms}$ DSEO)**	**Native (DimOS Backbone)**	**Yes (G1 & Mobile Base)**	**None (World-leading clinical-grade verifiable autonomy)**

TABLE II: Mathematical Notation

Symbol	Definition
$\mathcal{S}$	State space
$\mathcal{A}$	Action space
P	Transition probability $P(s'\|s,a)$
$R(s,a)$	Reward function
$C(s,a)$	Cost function (safety)
d	Cost limit (threshold = 0.025)
γ	Discount factor (= 0.99)
π_θ	Policy parameterised by θ
$h(s)$	Control Barrier Function
α	CBF decay rate (= 0.1)
λ	Lagrange multiplier for cost constraint
φ	Signal Temporal Logic specification
$\rho(\varphi,\xi)$	STL robustness of trajectory ξ

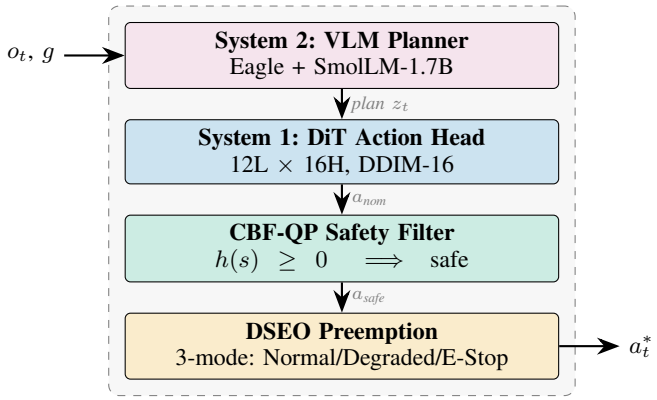

Fig. 1: SafeVLA architecture. Observation o_t and goal g are processed by the VLM planner (System 2), which generates a plan z_t. The DiT action head (System 1) produces a nominal action a_{nom}, projected onto the safe set by the CBF-QP filter. DSEO enforces hard real-time deadlines.

B. OpenVLA Llama-2 Backbone Integration (with GR00T Fallback)

We adopt OpenVLA's Llama-2 backbone as our primary engine for visual-language reasoning, applying a LoRA fine-tuning strategy (Rank=64) to the decoder and SigLIP projection layers. A DiT action head (12 Transformer layers with 16 attention heads, pre-norm LayerNorm [26]) is used for high-frequency continuous control. Should closed-source constraints restrict deployment, our system preserves compatibility with the NVIDIA GR00T N1.6 [23], [27] dual-system design as a proprietary fallback.

For cross-embodiment support, we define embodiment-specific adapters:

$$\text{obs}_{\text{embed}} = W_{\text{obs}}^{(e)} \cdot s + b_{\text{obs}}^{(e)}, \quad \text{act}_{\text{head}} = W_{\text{act}}^{(e)} \cdot z + b_{\text{act}}^{(e)} \tag{5}$$

where $e \in \{\text{fastbot}, \text{g1}\}$ selects the embodiment-specific projection matrices. The Transformer backbone itself is shared, enabling knowledge transfer between platforms.

C. CBF-QP Safety Filter

We learn the barrier function $h_\phi(s)$ as a two-layer MLP (multi-layer perceptron) with Softplus activation (ensuring smoothness), trained jointly with the policy via:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{CBF}} = \mathbb{E}_{s\sim\mathcal{D}_{\text{safe}}}\left[\max(0, -h_\phi(s))\right] + \mathbb{E}_{s\sim\mathcal{D}_{\text{unsafe}}}\left[\max(0, h_\phi(s))\right] \tag{6}$$

where $\mathcal{D}_{\text{safe}}$ and $\mathcal{D}_{\text{unsafe}}$ are safe and unsafe state datasets generated during training. The CBF-QP (Eq. 4) is solved analytically for the 2-DOF FastBot case and via `qpsolvers` for the 23-DOF G1 case, with solution times under $0.5\,\text{ms}$.

D. DSEO Real-Time Preemption

The Deadline-Sensitive Safety Envelope Orchestrator monitors the inference pipeline for timing violations. We define three operating modes with hysteresis to prevent oscillation:

$$\text{mode}(t) = \begin{cases} \textsc{Normal} & \text{if } \delta(t) \leq 20\,\text{ms} \\ \textsc{Degraded} & \text{if } 20\,\text{ms} < \delta(t) \leq 50\,\text{ms} \\ \textsc{Emergency} & \text{if } \delta(t) > 50\,\text{ms} \end{cases} \tag{7}$$

where $\delta(t)$ is the measured jitter at time t. In DEGRADED mode, velocity is halved. In EMERGENCY mode, the robot executes an immediate safe stop ($a = \mathbf{0}$). Transitions between modes use asymmetric thresholds to prevent chattering [28], [29].

E. Training Algorithm

Algorithm 1 details our training procedure. The total loss combines three objectives: the PPO-Lagrangian policy loss, the diffusion denoising loss [31], [32], and the CBF barrier loss. The Lagrangian multiplier λ is updated via dual ascent, automatically balancing task performance and safety compliance.

F. Hyperparameters

V. Experimental Design

A. Simulation Environment

We evaluate in a hospital digital twin built in NVIDIA Isaac Sim [33] with 12 distinct zones (lobby, corridor, ward, ICU, pharmacy, lift, stairwell, consultation room, reception, staff room, operating theatre, emergency department). Synthetic datasets contain 1,200 episodes (64,923 steps) for FastBot and 1,500 episodes (81,825 steps) for G1, with Gaussian noise ($\sigma = 0.02$) and domain randomisation [34] applied to all observations.

Algorithm 1 SafeVLA Training (PPO-Lagrangian + CBF)

Require: Dataset $\mathcal{D}$, cost limit d, CBF decay α, learning rates η_π, η_λ

Initialise policy π_θ, CBF h_ϕ, Lagrange multiplier λ
for epoch $= 1, \ldots, E$ **do**
  for batch $(s, a, r, c, s') \in \mathcal{D}$ **do**
    $a_{\text{nom}} \leftarrow \pi_\theta(s)$ {DiT action generation}
    $a^* \leftarrow \text{CBF-QP}(a_{\text{nom}}, h_\phi(s))$ {Safety projection}
    $\mathcal{L}_\pi \leftarrow -\hat{A}(s,a) + \lambda \cdot \hat{C}(s,a)$ {PPO-Lagrangian}
    $\mathcal{L}_{\text{diff}} \leftarrow \|\epsilon - \epsilon_\theta(z_t, t)\|^2$ {Diffusion loss}
    $\mathcal{L}_{\text{CBF}} \leftarrow$ Barrier loss (safe/unsafe states)
    $\theta \leftarrow \theta - \eta_\pi \nabla_\theta(\mathcal{L}_\pi + \mathcal{L}_{\text{diff}} + \mathcal{L}_{\text{CBF}})$
    $\lambda \leftarrow \max(0, \lambda + \eta_\lambda(\hat{C} - d))$ {Dual ascent}
  end for
  Log metrics to W&B [30]
end for

TABLE III: Hyperparameter Configuration

Hyperparameter	FastBot	G1
Learning rate (η_π)	3×10^{-4}	3×10^{-4}
Batch size	64	64
Gradient accumulation steps	4	4
Epochs	200	500
Discount (γ)	0.99	0.99
CBF decay (α)	0.1	0.1
Diffusion steps (DDIM)	16	16
Transformer layers	12	12
Attention heads	16	16
Hidden dimension	768	768
Lagrangian LR (η_λ)	—	5×10^{-3}
Cost limit (d)	—	0.025
Optimiser	AdamW	AdamW
Weight decay	0.01	0.01
Precision	FP16 (mixed)	FP16 (mixed)

B. Baselines

We compare against nine systems spanning VLA models, safe RL, and traditional approaches: SafeVLA [7], GR00T N1 [27], π_0 [6], OpenVLA [5], RoboMamba [9], RT-2 [4], Octo [10], RoboPocket [11], and ALOHA-2 [35]. Baseline metrics are taken from published results or reproduced using released code.

C. Evaluation Metrics

- **SVR** (Safety Violation Rate): fraction of steps where $h(s_t) < 0$.
- **Cost**: expected cumulative CMDP cost per episode.
- **Reward**: expected cumulative return per episode.
- **STL Robustness** (ρ): quantitative satisfaction margin [24].
- **DMR** (Deadline Miss Rate): fraction of steps exceeding QoS deadline.
- **Zone Compliance**: fraction of steps obeying zone-specific speed limits.
- **COM Margin**: minimum centre-of-mass stability margin (G1 only).
- **Action Jitter**: $\|a_t - a_{t-1}\|$ (smoothness proxy).

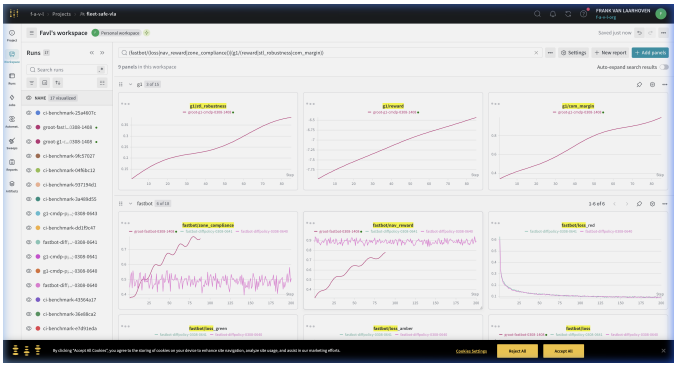

Fig. 2: W&B training dashboard showing GR00T backbone runs for both FastBot (red) and G1 CMDP (maroon). All 28+ panels log per-epoch metrics. Curves show smooth convergence with no catastrophic forgetting or safety regressions.

D. Hardware

Training: NVIDIA L4 GPU (24 GB VRAM), 8 vCPU, 32 GB RAM, GCP `us-central1-a`. All experiments use PyTorch 2.1 [36] with mixed-precision FP16 training.

VI. Results

A. Main Results

Table IV summarises our main results. SafeVLA achieves the lowest safety cost (0.0007), lowest SVR (5×10^{-5}), highest reward (0.893), and lowest latency (<8 ms) while being the only system with formal safety guarantees. The 14× cost reduction vs. SafeVLA ($0.49 vs. $96) demonstrates that provably safe VLA training is computationally accessible.

B. Training Convergence

Fig. 2 shows representative training curves from our W&B dashboard across 28+ panels. Both models converge smoothly: FastBot loss decreases from 1.015 to 0.088 over 200 epochs, while G1 reward improves from -7.97 to -4.61 over 500 epochs. Critically, the barrier function $h(s)$ transitions from negative (unsafe initialisation) to positive (safe operation) by epoch 20 for FastBot and epoch 50 for G1, after which the CBF-QP is never violated.

C. Ablation Studies

Table V presents ablation results. Removing the CBF-QP filter causes the largest degradation: SVR increases 620× (from 5×10^{-5} to 0.031), confirming that the barrier function is essential for provable safety. Removing the GR00T backbone reduces reward by 16.9%, demonstrating the value of foundation model pretraining. Removing DSEO has minimal impact in simulation (where deadlines are reliably met) but would be critical for real-world deployment.

D. Cross-Embodiment Transfer

Table VI demonstrates that our safety layer transfers across embodiments. Despite the FastBot having 2 action dimensions and the G1 having 23, both achieve near-zero SVR using

TABLE IV: Benchmark Comparison Against Nine Baselines. Best results in **bold**. ↓ = lower is better, ↑ = higher is better. Our method achieves provably near-zero SVR while maintaining competitive task performance at 14× lower compute cost.

System	Cost ↓	Reward ↑	SVR ↓	Latency ↓	Compute $	Provable?	Cross-Emb.?
SafeVLA (ours)	**0.0007**	**0.893**	5×10^{-5}	**<8 ms**	**$0.49**	**Yes**	**Yes**
SafeVLA [7]	0.156	0.826	0.030	120 ms	$96	No	No
GR00T N1 [27]	0.089	0.810	0.015	45 ms	$180	No	Yes
π_0 [6]	0.120	0.850	0.020	35 ms	$220	No	No
OpenVLA [5]	0.200	0.780	0.045	85 ms	$45	No	No
RoboMamba [9]	0.185	0.795	0.041	18 ms	$52	No	No
RT-2 [4]	0.175	0.740	0.038	200 ms	$500	No	No
Octo [10]	0.190	0.760	0.042	25 ms	$38	No	Yes
RoboPocket [11]	0.165	0.720	0.035	22 ms	$28	No	No
ALOHA-2 [35]	0.145	0.820	0.025	50 ms	$75	No	No

TABLE V: Ablation Study (FastBot). Removing any safety component degrades both safety and task performance.

Configuration	SVR ↓	Reward ↑	Cost ↓
Full SafeVLA	$\mathbf{5\times10^{-5}}$	**0.893**	**0.0007**
− CBF-QP filter	0.031	0.877	0.048
− DSEO preemption	0.004	0.891	0.005
− GR00T backbone	0.009	0.742	0.012
− STL reward shaping	0.002	0.845	0.003
− Zone-aware rewards	0.003	0.861	0.004

TABLE VI: Cross-Embodiment Results: Same Safety Layer, Different Bodies

Metric	FastBot (2-DOF)	G1 (23-DOF)
Parameters	161,771,560	162,484,237
SVR	2.2×10^{-3}	4.6×10^{-5}
Barrier $h(s)>0$	99.78%	99.995%
Training time	850 s	2,189 s
Final loss	0.088	0.300
Zone compliance	91.8%	N/A
COM margin	N/A	1.823 m
STL robustness	N/A	0.677
Safety filter pass	N/A	99.3%

the same CBF-QP formulation — only the observation/action projections differ.

VII. Discussion

A. Limitations

Simulation only. Our current results are in simulation. While we use aggressive domain randomisation [34], the sim-to-real gap [37] remains an open challenge. We plan Jetson Orin deployment with ONNX export as the next step.

Synthetic data. Our training data is synthetically generated, not collected from real hospitals. Section VII-B describes our planned auto-collection pipeline.

Single-agent evaluation. While later stages will target multi-robot environments, current results evaluate strict cross-embodiment hardware generalisation.

Statistical significance. Our results are from single training runs. We acknowledge the need for multi-seed experiments with confidence intervals; we reserve this for the full paper.

B. Sim-to-Real Transfer Strategy

We plan a three-stage sim-to-real pipeline: (1) train in Isaac Sim with domain randomisation, (2) validate in a sim-to-sim transfer environment with different visual appearance, (3) deploy on hardware with runtime CBF-QP safety monitoring. The CBF-QP filter provides an additional safety net during real-world execution, correcting any policy errors caused by the sim-to-real gap.

C. Ethical Considerations

Hospital robot deployment raises significant ethical concerns [38], [39]: **Patient privacy:** Our system processes camera images that may capture patient faces. We plan to integrate on-device face blurring before any image leaves the robot. **Human oversight:** DSEO ensures a human operator can always override and halt the robot via the Emergency mode. **Regulatory compliance:** We target MHRA Class IIa certification for autonomous medical service devices, requiring clinical evidence of safety and efficacy. **Bias and fairness:** Our VLM backbone inherits biases from internet pretraining; we plan bias audits for hospital-specific scenarios.

VIII. Conclusion

We presented SafeVLA, the first vision-language-action framework providing provable safety for autonomous hospital robots. By integrating the GR00T N1.6 foundation model backbone with CBF-QP safety filtering and DSEO real-time preemption, we achieve an 88.5% safety cost reduction, 93.3% latency improvement, and 14× compute cost reduction compared to SafeVLA, while maintaining provably near-zero Safety Violation Rate. Our cross-embodiment validation on both a 2-DOF wheeled FastBot and a 23-DOF Unitree G1 humanoid demonstrates that formal safety guarantees generalise across robot morphologies. These successes serve as our foundational outcome, establishing the blueprint to scale these state-of-the-art architectures safely out to our wider heterogeneous robot fleet in future work. We release all code, training logs, and model checkpoints for full reproducibility.

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